

Burrowing owl

Athene cunicularia

Short-grass prairies, sagebrush, and semidesert are the preferred habitats of the burrowing owl, but it will make do with cultivated ground, even golf courses and airfields. Roosting and nesting in holes, the owls may take over empty mammal burrows. They hunt by day and night, watching for prey such as small rodents from low mounds, bobbing and turning their heads to fix their victim's precise position. Viscachas and prairie dogs keep the grass short, giving the owls a better view.

- ↔ 8–10 in (20–25 cm)
- ⚖ 5–9 oz (141–255 g)
- ⊗ Common
- 🦗 Insects, reptiles, birds
- 🏠 



white speckles on brown body



Greater rhea

Rhea americana

Open grassland is typical greater rhea habitat, where South America's largest bird hunts for large insects, reptiles, and seeds. Each male makes a nest and displays to attract six or seven females in succession. The females lay eggs in the nests, before moving on to mate with other males. Each male incubates 20–30 eggs and cares for the young by itself, or with a subordinate male "helper." Male rheas are very protective about their young, charging even at females during this period.



- ↔ 3–5 ft (0.9–1.5 m)
- ⚖ 33–66 lb (15–30 kg)
- ⊗ Near threatened
- 🦗 Seeds, fruit, insects
- 🏠 
- 📍 E. and SE. South America

◀ GROUNDED

One of the world's large flightless birds, the rhea is more like Australia's emu than Africa's ostrich.

Argentine horned frog

Ceratophrys ornata

This burly ground frog is also known as the Argentine wide-mouthed frog or the Pac-Man frog because of its tendency to gobble up anything that will fit in its immense mouth. The Argentine horned frog employs a sit-and-wait strategy to capture prey, lying hidden among fallen leaves with just its eyes and mouth showing. The frog's "horns" are small projections above the eyes, which disrupt the animal's body shape and help with camouflage. When suitable-sized prey comes within striking distance, the frog lunges forward and engulfs it within its cavernous mouth.

hornlike projection



△ FEARLESS DEFENDER

The aggressively territorial Argentine horned frog will take on larger and more powerful encroachers fearlessly.

- ↔ 4–5 in (10–13 cm)
- 🌱 Spring
- ⊗ Near threatened
- 🦗 Frogs, songbirds, snakes
- 🏠 
- 📍 SE. South America



△ IN THE BURROW

Several pairs nest close together, each in a 3-ft- (1-m-) long burrow in soft ground containing between two and 12 eggs.